

Northern Renaissance

While Italian artists embraced ideals of classical art and humanism, in northern Europe their counterparts were more influenced by Gothic art. Fresco did not flourish, and artists began using oil paint rather than tempera. Ideas were exchanged through trade and the invention of the printing press in c.1439 by Johannes Gutenberg (c.1398–1468) enabled books to be mass-produced, forever changing the structure of society.

Change was also driven by revolt. In 1517, German theologian Martin Luther (1483–1546) criticized the Catholic Church, triggering the Protestant Reformation that flourished in northern Europe. Protestant artists made Christian subjects more temporal, often in contemporary domestic settings. Figures were depicted from life, many images included symbolic meanings, and all were meticulously rendered. Exceptionally skilful Northern Renaissance artists included Albrecht Dürer, Jan van Eyck, Rogier van der Weyden, Robert Campin (c.1375–1444), also known as the Master of Flémalle, Hans Memling, Matthias Grünewald and Hugo van der Goes (c.1435–82).



Van der Weyden, *The Descent from the Cross*, c.1435